How can we understand India's and China's reluctance to discuss the border for several years? Why did they adopt seemingly contradictory and inconsistent positions over time? Why in the end did they fail to come to an agreement?

On the reluctance to discuss the border, we have seen that both sides were split between a sooner and a later school. The split related to how ready they were to negotiate. Essentially, both governments were new and were in the process of consolidating their rule at a time of many challenges. Nehru and Panikkar were candid about India's limited capabilities in administering and effectively controlling the outer reaches of the country. Mao and Zhou may well have had the same thoughts about their country, which in land area was two and a half times the size of India. India had just come out of a freedom struggle, a world war, a partition and near civil war (between the Congress party and the Muslim League), and a regional conflict with Pakistan. China too had come out of a civil war, a world war, a partition (the Kuomintang having departed and set up an alternative government in Taiwan), and a regional war in Korea. At the same time, both were entering an unstable international system that was dominated by two opposing superpowers.

India's and China's contradictory and inconsistent statements and actions are also understandable. Neither leadership had negotiated territorial matters. They were not diplomats and had only fledgling foreign services at their disposal. From all accounts, India had only a few historians and cartographers who knew much about the borderlands. Beyond expertise, the documentary and cartographic materials on borders and treaties going back hundreds of years may have been dispersed and damaged in part because of Partition. Some of the materials were in Britain. Nehru only really felt that he had comprehended India's borderlands with China when Gopal briefed him in 1960. Gopal was forced to go to London in order to consult documents and maps that were not even available in India.

Until 1956–57, Beijing was still trying to come to grips with its historical records and maps. The Chinese had produced a report on the border by 1953 but were looking for additional materials. In May 1958,